



**TRIBHUVAN UNIVERSITY
FACULTY OF EDUCATION
SUKUNA MULTIPLE CAMPUS**

**A Final Report on
IMPACT OF ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE (AI) TOOLS ON STUDENTS'
LEARNING AND ACADEMIC INTEGRITY**

Submitted By:

Abishek Khawas(78214004)

**A Project Report Submitted to
Department of BICTE, Faculty of Education, Tribhuvan University
in partial fulfilment of the requirements for the degree of**

Bachelor of Information Communication Technology in Education (BICTE)

Sundarharaincha, Morang, Nepal

January 2026

CERTIFICATE FROM THE SUPERVISOR

This is to certify that the research report entitled “Impact Of Artificial Intelligence (AI) Tools On Students’ Learning And Academic Integrity” is an academic work done by Abishek Khawas (Regd No.: 9-2-214-36-2021).

The report is submitted in partial fulfillment of the requirements for the degree of Bachelor in Information, Communication and Technology Education (BICTE) at Sukuna Multiple Campus, Tribhuvan University, under my guidance and supervision. To the best of my knowledge and belief, the information presented by him/her in this project report is original and has not been submitted earlier.

Mr. Biplab Dhakal

Supervisor

Department of BICTE

Sukuna Multiple Campus

Date: January 2026

APPROVAL SHEET

This is to certify that the research project entitled “Impact Of Artificial Intelligence (AI) Tools On Students’ Learning And Academic Integrity” has been prepared and submitted by Abishek Khawas in partial fulfillment of the requirements for the degree of Bachelor of Education in Information Communication Technology (BICTE) under the Faculty of Education, Tribhuvan University.

This research work has been examined and approved by the undersigned. In our professional opinion, the project meets the required academic standards with regard to relevance, depth, and overall quality.

Supervisor

Mr. Biplab Dhakal

Date: January 2026

Head of Department

Er. Santosh Dahal

Date: January 2026

External Examiner:

Date: January 2026

ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS

I would like to express my sincere gratitude to all those who contributed to the successful completion of this research report.

My deepest appreciation goes to my supervisor, **Mr. Biplab Dhakal**, for his invaluable guidance, constructive criticism, constant encouragement, and dedicated support from the inception to the final draft of this work.

I am also thankful to the management and faculty of **Sukuna Multiple Campus**, especially the **BICTE Department**, for providing the necessary academic resources and a supportive environment conducive to research.

I extend my sincere gratitude to the **External Examiner** and the **Focal Person** for their valuable time and insightful feedback during the evaluation process.

A special note of thanks goes to all the students and educators who participated in the data collection process; their honest responses and cooperation were essential to the success of this study.

Finally, I am deeply grateful to my family and friends for their unwavering motivation, patience, and emotional support throughout my academic journey.

Abishek Khawas

Regd. No.: 9-2-214-36-2021

January 2026

ABSTRACT

The rapid expansion of Artificial Intelligence (AI) tools has significantly transformed contemporary education, creating both opportunities for enhanced learning and challenges to academic integrity. This study investigated the impact of AI tools on students' learning processes, critical thinking, and ethical awareness in higher secondary and undergraduate education using a quantitative research design. Data were collected from 39 students through a structured questionnaire and analyzed using descriptive statistics, including frequencies, percentages, mean scores, and grand mean analysis. The findings reveal a very high level of AI integration in academic routines (Mean = 4.44), with tools such as ChatGPT being used almost universally and more than half of the respondents engaging with AI on a daily basis. Students strongly perceived AI tools as beneficial for learning and cognitive development (Mean = 4.26), particularly for problem-solving and research-related tasks. At the same time, ethical awareness among students was found to be high (Mean = 4.59), with a significant proportion acknowledging the risks of plagiarism and over-dependence. The need for institutional strategies, including formal training and clear ethical guidelines, also received strong support (Mean = 4.38). The overall grand mean score of 4.42 indicates a strong consensus that AI tools are both essential and transformative in modern education, provided they are used responsibly. The study concludes that AI itself is not inherently detrimental to academic integrity; rather, the key challenge lies in the absence of structured guidance and ethical training. Therefore, institutions must adopt AI literacy programs, redesign assessment practices, and establish clear policies to ensure that AI functions as a tool for learning enhancement rather than a substitute for independent critical thinking.

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LIST OF ABBREVIATIONS

Abbreviation	Full Form
AI	Artificial Intelligence
BICTE	Bachelor of Information Communication Technology in Education
ICAI	International Center for Academic Integrity
ICT	Information and Communication Technology
LLM	Large Language Model (e.g., ChatGPT, Gemini)
TU	Tribhuvan University
UNESCO	United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization

CHAPTER I

INTRODUCTION

1.1 Background of the Study

Education is currently undergoing a significant digital transformation. In Nepalese classrooms, students are no longer dependent solely on traditional textbooks and lectures; instead, they are increasingly using Artificial Intelligence (AI) tools such as ChatGPT to understand complex concepts, complete assignments, and support their academic learning. While this technological shift has made learning faster, more flexible, and more accessible, it also raises an important question: are students enhancing their learning abilities, or are they becoming overly dependent on intelligent machines? This study seeks to explore this tension between academic efficiency and the core values of academic honesty within the Nepalese educational context.

In educational settings, AI technologies facilitate personalized and self-paced learning by allowing students to study according to their individual abilities, needs, and learning styles. Students who struggle academically can benefit from simplified explanations and repeated practice, while advanced learners can explore deeper insights and alternative viewpoints. Consequently, AI tools hold strong potential to improve student engagement, conceptual understanding, and overall learning outcomes.

Despite these advantages, the rapid integration of AI tools has raised serious concerns related to academic integrity and ethical conduct. The ease with which AI can generate complete answers, essays, and problem solutions may discourage students from engaging in critical thinking, reflection, and independent problem-solving. Excessive reliance on AI tools may result in superficial learning, cognitive dependency, and weakened development of higher-order thinking skills.

Educational institutions and educators also face growing challenges in evaluating students' original work and ensuring fair assessment. Traditional assessment methods are increasingly inadequate for distinguishing between student-generated and AI-generated content. Furthermore, many students remain uncertain about the ethical boundaries of AI use, while institutional policies governing AI integration are still in the process of development.

Given AI's dual role as both a powerful learning support tool and a potential threat to academic integrity, it is essential to examine how AI tools influence students' learning processes and ethical behavior. Understanding students' experiences, perceptions, and ethical awareness is crucial for designing responsible educational practices, effective institutional

policies, and informed pedagogical strategies.

1.2 Statement of the Problem

Despite the growing popularity of AI tools in education, their use has generated several academic and ethical challenges. While AI technologies provide convenience, efficiency, and academic support, there is increasing concern that students may misuse these tools for plagiarism, cheating, and shortcut learning. The availability of instant, ready-made answers may discourage students from engaging in essential learning activities such as research, analysis, reflection, and critical thinking.

Another major issue lies in the lack of clarity regarding ethical AI use. Many educational institutions have not yet established comprehensive guidelines or awareness programs related to acceptable and unacceptable use of AI tools. As a result, students may unknowingly violate academic integrity policies, leading to unintentional misconduct.

Furthermore, educators face difficulties in evaluating students' genuine understanding and originality of work in an AI-assisted learning environment. The increasing sophistication of AI-generated content complicates assessment practices and raises questions about fairness and credibility in academic evaluation.

Therefore, there is a pressing need to investigate how students are actually using AI tools in their academic lives whether these tools are enhancing meaningful learning or fostering dependency and academic dishonesty. This study seeks to address this gap by exploring the impact of AI tools on students' learning experiences and academic integrity, as well as identifying conditions under which AI use can be ethical and educationally beneficial.

1.3 Purposes of the Study

General Objective

The general objective of this study is to explore the impact of Artificial Intelligence (AI) tools on students' learning processes and academic integrity through a quantitative research approach.

Specific Objectives

The specific objectives of the study are:

- i. To investigate the ways in which students use AI tools for academic purposes such as assignments, research, and exam preparation.
- ii. To explore students' perceptions of how AI tools influence their engagement, comprehension, and critical thinking skills.
- iii. To examine ethical concerns related to AI use, particularly issues of plagiarism,

academic dishonesty, and over-dependence.

- iv. To suggest strategies for promoting responsible, ethical, and effective use of AI tools in educational settings.

1.4 Research Questions

This study seeks to answer the following research questions:

- i. How are students integrating AI tools into their academic activities?
- ii. How do students perceive the impact of AI tools on their learning and thinking skills?
- iii. What ethical challenges do students and educators face regarding the use of AI tools?
- iv. What strategies can institutions adopt to encourage ethical and effective use of AI in education?

1.5 Significance of the Study

This study holds significant value for a wide range of educational stakeholders, including students, educators, institutional administrators, and policymakers. It offers a deeper understanding of students' real-life experiences with Artificial Intelligence (AI) tools and highlights both the opportunities and challenges associated with their integration into academic learning. The findings provide practical insights that can support and inform the development of AI literacy programs, institutional policies, and pedagogical strategies that promote academic integrity while responsibly embracing technological innovation.

By presenting direct evidence of students' usage patterns and perceptions, this research bridges the gap between theoretical debates surrounding AI and the practical realities currently emerging within classrooms. It serves as a valuable resource for educators seeking to adapt their teaching approaches in a rapidly evolving, technology-driven educational environment, ensuring that the human dimensions of teaching and learning are effectively balanced with machine-assisted efficiency.

Furthermore, the study contributes to the growing body of literature on AI in education, particularly within the context of developing countries, where digital transformation is occurring at an accelerated pace. By identifying ethical concerns and highlighting responsible practices, the research supports a balanced and informed integration of AI technologies in academic settings. Its significance also extends to institutional planning and policy development, as it provides empirical evidence that encourages a shift from reactive restrictions toward proactive and ethical governance frameworks. Ultimately, this study promotes the cultivation of AI literacy, empowering students to use AI tools as instruments for intellectual growth rather than mere academic shortcuts, thereby safeguarding the long-term value of

academic qualifications and the development of independent critical thinking skills.

1.6 Delimitations of the Study

Delimitations

- i. The study is limited to higher secondary and undergraduate students.
- ii. It focuses on selected AI tools related to language processing and content generation, such as ChatGPT and similar platforms.

Limitations

- i. The findings are based on self-reported data from students and educators, which may involve subjective perceptions.
- ii. Due to the rapid evolution of AI technologies, the results may not remain universally applicable over time.

CHAPTER II

LITERATURE REVIEW, CONCEPTUAL FRAMEWORK, AND RESEARCH METHODOLOGY

2.1 Introduction to the Chapter

This chapter presents a review of relevant literature related to the use of artificial intelligence (AI) tools in education, particularly focusing on students' learning and academic integrity. It also explains the conceptual framework of the study and outlines the research methodology adopted to achieve the objectives of the study.

2.2 Literature Review

2.2.1 Review of Theoretical Literature

Artificial Intelligence (AI) has become an increasingly integral component of contemporary educational systems. Generative AI tools such as ChatGPT, Grammarly, and similar platforms assist learners by offering instant feedback, conceptual explanations, language support, and idea generation. According to UNESCO (2023), the integration of AI in education holds substantial potential to promote personalized learning, enhance learner autonomy, and strengthen academic support mechanisms. At the same time, theoretical discussions caution that unregulated or excessive reliance on AI may contribute to dependency and ethical challenges in learning environments.

Constructivist learning theory posits that meaningful learning occurs when students actively construct knowledge through engagement and interaction rather than passive information reception (Vygotsky, 1978). From this perspective, AI tools can function as a form of scaffolding by providing adaptive assistance that supports independent exploration and understanding. However, theoretical critiques argue that over-reliance on AI-generated outputs may reduce cognitive effort, thereby limiting the development of critical thinking and higher-order reasoning skills.

Within the Nepali context, recent theoretical discourse has increasingly focused on institutional readiness for AI integration. Scholars such as Ranabhat et al. (2024) suggest that although the perceived usefulness of AI tools among Nepali students is high, the absence of structured theoretical frameworks and institutional guidance has created a form of "guidance vacuum." Additionally, academic integrity theory emphasizes principles of honesty, responsibility, and fairness in educational practices. The International Center for Academic Integrity (ICAI, 2021) highlights that the ease of generating AI-assisted content poses significant challenges to traditional assessment models, potentially undermining academic

fairness and ethical accountability. Together, these theoretical perspectives underscore the need for clearly defined frameworks to ensure that AI supports learning without compromising academic integrity.

2.2.2 Review of Empirical Literature

Numerous empirical studies conducted at the global level have examined the influence of Artificial Intelligence tools on students' learning outcomes and academic behaviors. Kasneci et al. (2023) reported that AI-supported learning environments can enhance students' learning efficiency and conceptual understanding when such tools are employed as supplementary academic resources. In contrast, Cotton, Cotton, and Shipway (2023) cautioned that unrestricted access to generative AI may contribute to increased academic dishonesty and a decline in students' motivation to produce original academic work.

Empirical evidence from Nepal reflects similar patterns while highlighting context-specific challenges. Adhikari (2024), in a study of Nepali undergraduate students, observed that AI tools such as ChatGPT are predominantly used for rephrasing content and generating ideas rather than producing complete assignments. Despite these benefits, students expressed concerns regarding potential long-term cognitive dependency. Likewise, Ghimire, Bhattarai, and Baral (2024) found that although AI significantly improves academic efficiency, it may weaken independent research and analytical skills in the absence of clear institutional guidelines. Supporting this perspective, Lawaju et al. (2024) demonstrated that students' attitudes toward technology and perceived ease of use are the primary drivers of AI adoption in Nepal, often outweighing formal academic policies or instructional guidance. Collectively, these empirical findings suggest that in developing educational contexts such as Nepal, the adoption of AI tools is largely student-driven and advancing more rapidly than institutional mechanisms designed to regulate and guide their ethical use.

2.3 Implications of the Review of Literature

The reviewed literature indicates that AI tools have both positive and negative impacts on students' learning and academic integrity. While global literature provides a broad ethical framework, the localized studies from Nepal highlight a critical "Policy-Practice Gap." It is evident that while Nepali students are rapidly integrating AI into their academic routines, there is a lack of localized research specifically targeting campuses outside the capital region.

These findings justify the need for the present study at Sukuna Multiple Campus to explore how students in this specific academic environment are balancing AI-assisted efficiency with the traditional values of academic honesty. By identifying these localized usage

patterns and ethical perceptions, this research aims to bridge the gap between student behaviour and institutional policy requirements in the Nepalese higher education sector.

2.3.1 Conceptual Framework

The conceptual framework of this study is developed based on the reviewed literature and the objectives of the research.

i. Independent Variables:

Use of AI tools (e.g., ChatGPT, Gemini, Grammarly, Bard), frequency of use, type of academic tasks

ii. Dependent Variables:

Students' learning outcomes (engagement, understanding, performance) and academic integrity

iii. Moderating Factors:

Awareness of institutional policies, ethical understanding, teacher guidance

The framework assumes that the use of AI tools directly influences students' learning and academic integrity, while ethical awareness and institutional guidance moderate this relationship.

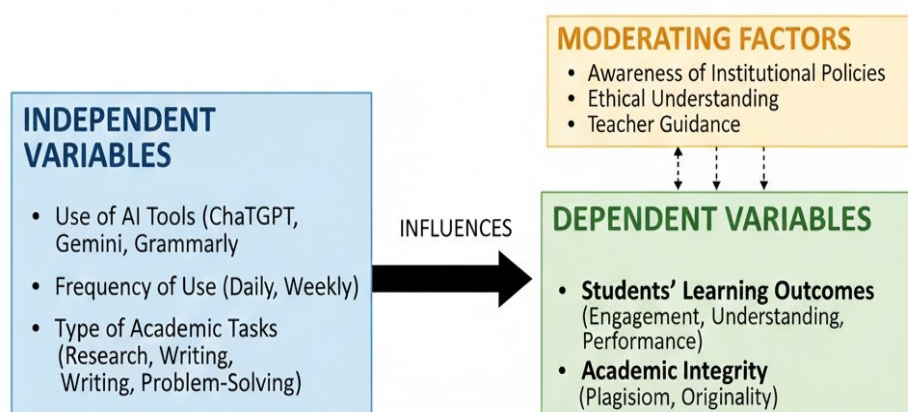


Figure 1: Conceptual Framework Diagram

2.3.2 Research Methodology

Research Design

This study utilizes a Descriptive Survey Research Design. It is selected to capture a "snapshot" of how students currently perceive and interact with AI tools. The design focuses on

documenting existing trends and ethical concerns in a standardized manner without attempting to influence participant behavior.

Sources of Data

A dual-source approach was used to balance theoretical context with empirical evidence:

- i. **Primary Data:** Collected firsthand through an original online survey. This provides raw, unfiltered insights into how students actually use tools like ChatGPT.
- ii. **Secondary Data:** Gathered from high-impact academic journals, UNESCO frameworks, and books on digital ethics. This helps in comparing local findings with global educational trends.

Population, Sample, and Sampling Procedure

Target Population: All students currently enrolled in higher education programs

- i. **Sampling Technique: Convenience Sampling** (Non-probability). This was chosen for its pragmatism and efficiency in reaching respondents within a limited time-frame.
- ii. **Sampling Criteria:** Participants were required to be active students with prior exposure to digital learning tools.
- iii. **Reach:** The researcher leveraged academic networks and digital platforms (social media/messaging) to connect with willing participants.

Data Collection Tool: Structured Questionnaire via Google Forms

To gather primary data on AI's impact, a structured questionnaire was developed and administered electronically using Google Forms. This digital approach was selected to ensure data accuracy, participant accessibility, and efficient real-time analysis. The process followed the structure below:

Questionnaire Development

- i. **Literature Review:** The survey items were adapted from existing validated studies concerning AI in education (e.g., UNESCO's guidelines and studies on Likert-scale items for cognitive skill development).
- ii. **Expert Validation:** To ensure clarity and alignment with the research objectives, the questionnaire was reviewed by two ICT faculty members from Sukuna Multiple Campus. Their feedback was used to refine technical terms related to AI.
- iii. **Pilot Testing:** A pilot test was conducted with 5 students to identify any ambiguous wording and to ensure a logical flow between the four sections of the study.

Questionnaire Structure

The final questionnaire was organized into three core components to address all research objectives:

- i. **Demographics:** This section collected basic information such as the student's semester, age, and gender.
- ii. **Likert-Scale Items:** A 5-point Likert scale (ranging from 1 = Strongly Disagree to 5 = Strongly Agree) was used to measure students' perceptions regarding learning efficiency, critical thinking, and ethical concerns.
- iii. **Multiple-Choice Questions:** These were used to identify the specific types of AI tools (e.g., ChatGPT, Grammarly, Bard) students use and the frequency of their usage.

Distribution and Administration

- i. **Dissemination:** The Google Forms link was distributed through the college's official Facebook groups and direct messaging platforms (Messenger/WhatsApp) to reach the target participants.
- ii. **Follow-up:** To ensure a high response rate, two follow-up reminders were sent over a period of two weeks.
- iii. **Data Recording:** A total of 39 **participants** successfully completed the survey. All responses were automatically synchronized and recorded in Google Sheets for the subsequent mean calculation and thematic analysis.

Data Collection Procedure

The data collection was conducted through a systematic digital process to ensure accuracy and participant engagement. The procedure followed these key steps:

- i. **Platform Selection:** The research utilized **Google Forms** for its accessibility across mobile and desktop devices, allowing for a wider geographical reach.
- ii. **Introductory Briefing:** Each survey began with a mandatory briefing that explained the study's academic purpose and ethical guidelines. This built rapport and ensured sincere responses.
- iii. **Dissemination:** The survey link was distributed via student-centric digital channels, including social media groups, messaging apps (WhatsApp/Messenger), and educational forums.
- iv. **Data Management:** Responses were automatically and securely stored in a synchronized Google Sheet, eliminating manual transcription errors and ensuring data integrity.

Methods of Data Analysis

Once the target number of responses was achieved, the data underwent a rigorous cleaning process to remove any incomplete or duplicate entries. The study employed descriptive statistical analysis as the primary method for interpreting the results. This involved calculating frequency distributions and percentages to identify common student behaviours and attitudes. To enhance clarity and interpretation, the data were presented using pie charts and bar graphs. These visual representations helped identify observable patterns and trends, such as the relationship between frequency of AI use and students' perceptions of critical thinking. The final stage of analysis involved an interpretive comparison of the statistical findings with relevant academic theories and prior research discussed in the literature review.

Ethical Considerations

The integrity of this research was maintained through strict adherence to the following ethical protocols to ensure the safety and rights of all participants:

Informed Consent

Participation in this study was entirely voluntary. Every student and educator was provided with a clear explanation of the study's purpose and procedures before participation. No individual was coerced or forced to participate, and they retained the right to withdraw at any stage.

Anonymity

To encourage honest responses especially regarding sensitive issues like plagiarism and AI misuse absolute anonymity was guaranteed. No personal identifiers such as names, email addresses, or specific institutional details were collected or recorded in the final data.

Confidentiality

All data collected through the online survey was kept strictly confidential. No personal identifiers like names or email addresses were stored. The raw data was used only for statistical analysis to ensure that individual responses remain anonymous and protected.

Academic Honesty (Researcher's Integrity)

The researcher ensured that the study itself adhered to the highest standards of academic integrity. This included avoiding any form of data manipulation and providing full credit through proper citations to all scholars and secondary sources referenced in this report.

CHAPTER III

DATA PRESENTATION, ANALYSIS, CONCLUSION & ACTION IMPLICATIONS

3.1 Organisation / Respondent Profile

This study collected primary data from 39 student respondents using a structured questionnaire administered through Google Forms. The respondents were selected purposively, focusing on students who actively use AI tools for academic purposes. The participants represent higher education students enrolled in different academic disciplines.

All respondents reported at least some level of exposure to AI tools, indicating that AI-assisted learning has become a common practice in contemporary academic settings. The use of an online data collection tool ensured ease of access, anonymity, and voluntary participation, thereby enhancing the reliability of responses.

3.2 Data Presentation

This section presents the data collected from 39 respondents through a Google Form questionnaire. The data are presented objective-wise using frequencies, percentages, and graphical representations to provide a clear overview of students' responses.

Section 1 Objective: To investigate the various ways students integrate AI tools into their academic tasks.

1. Which AI tools do you use for your academic work?
39 responses

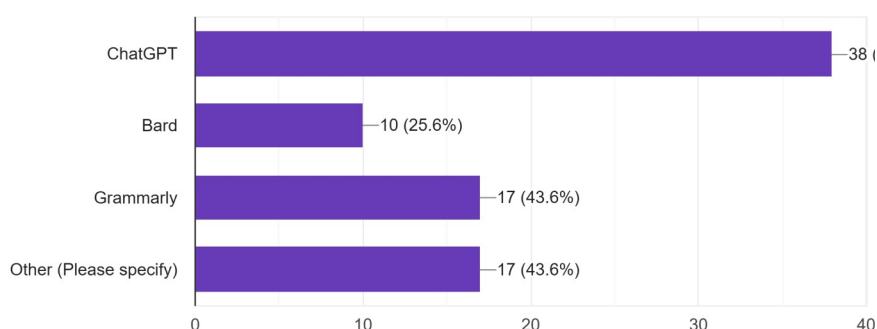


Figure 2: Distribution of AI Tools Used by Students

The data reveals that ChatGPT is the most dominant tool, used by an overwhelming 97.4% of the respondents. Both Grammarly and the "Other" category follow as secondary preferences, with each being utilized by 43.6% (17 respondents) of the group. Bard (now known as Gemini) is the least common among the listed options, used by only 25.6% (10

respondents) of the students. Overall, the chart indicates that while students experiment with various platforms, ChatGPT has become a near-universal standard for AI assistance in their academic environment.

2. How often do you use AI tools for assignments or study?
38 responses

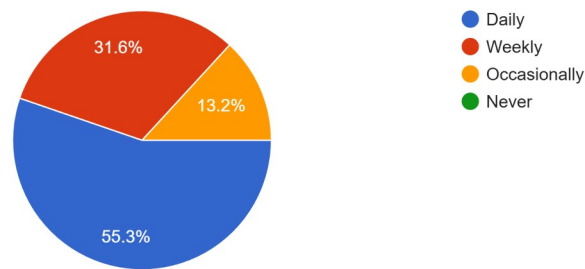


Figure 3: Frequency of AI Tool Usage Among Respondents

Regarding the frequency of use, the data from 38 respondents shows a high level of regular engagement with AI tools. Over half of the participants, 55.3%, report using these tools on a Daily basis, while 31.6% use them Weekly. A smaller segment of 13.2% engages with AI Occasionally, and notably, 0% of respondents selected "Never." This indicates that AI has become a consistent and integrated part of the academic routine for the vast majority of students surveyed.

3. For which tasks do you mostly use AI tools?
39 responses

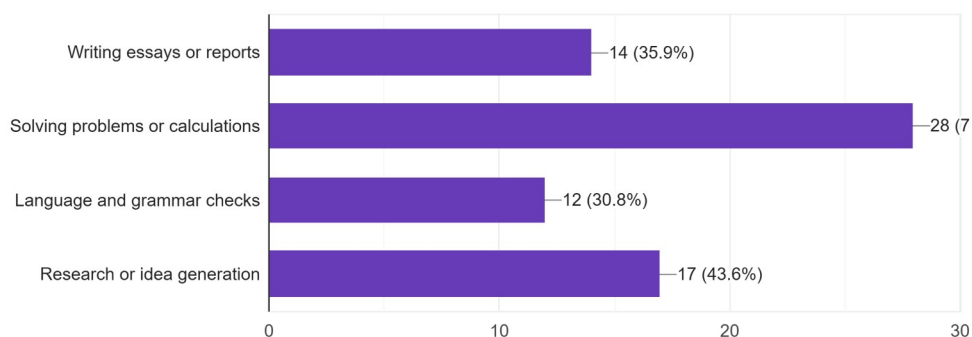


Figure 4: Primary Academic Tasks Performed Using AI Tools

When examining the specific academic tasks for which AI is utilized, the 39 respondents indicated that Solving problems or calculations is the most common use case, cited by 71.8% (28 students). Research or idea generation is the second most popular task at 43.6% (17 students), followed closely by Writing essays or reports at 35.9% (14 students). Language and grammar checks represent the least frequent primary use among the listed categories, though still utilized by 30.8% (12 students) of the group. This suggests that students are primarily using AI as a functional problem-solving assistant rather than just a basic editing tool.

4. Do you feel AI tools help you understand your subjects better?
39 responses

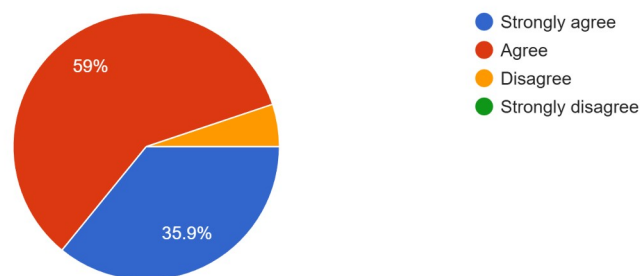


Figure 5: Students' Perceived Speed and Ease of Learning with AI

A significant majority of students, 59%, reported that they Agree with the sentiment that AI tools enhance their understanding of their subjects, while an additional 35.9% Strongly agree. Combined, nearly 95% of the participants feel that these tools are beneficial to their learning process. In contrast, only a very small minority expressed a negative view, with just 5.1% choosing to Disagree, and 0% indicating that they "Strongly disagree." This suggests that the vast majority of students see AI as a valuable educational aid rather than just a shortcut for completing tasks.

5. Do you use AI tools independently or with guidance from teachers?

39 responses

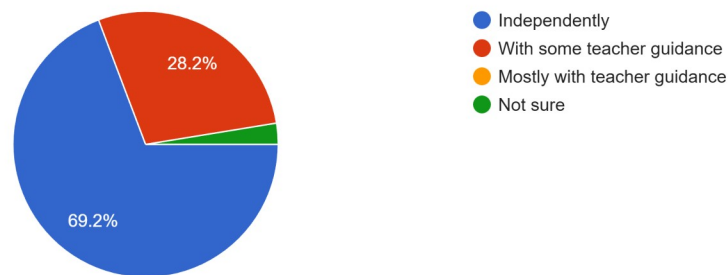


Figure 6: Nature of AI Tool Usage

The survey data regarding student autonomy reveals that a substantial majority of the 39 respondents, 69.2%, use AI tools Independently. A smaller but significant portion, 28.2%, reported using these tools With some teacher guidance. Notably, none of the participants indicated using them "Mostly with teacher guidance," while a very small fraction remained Not sure. These results suggest that while there is some level of academic oversight, the vast majority of students are self-navigating AI technology to support their learning and assignments.

Section 2 Objective: To understand students' perceptions of how AI tools affect their learning and thinking skills.

6. How do AI tools affect your engagement during study?

39 responses

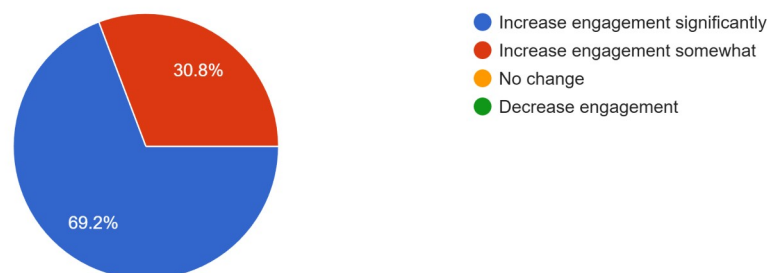


Figure 7: Impact of AI Tools on Subject Understanding

The survey results reveal a universally positive impact of AI tools on student engagement. A significant majority of 69.2% of participants reported that these tools increase engagement significantly, while the remaining 30.8% stated that they increase engagement

somewhat. Notably, not a single respondent indicated that there was "No change" or a "Decrease" in their engagement levels. This data strongly suggests that students find AI tools to be effective catalysts for active learning, helping them remain more focused and involved in their academic studies.

7. Have AI tools improved your critical thinking skills?
39 responses

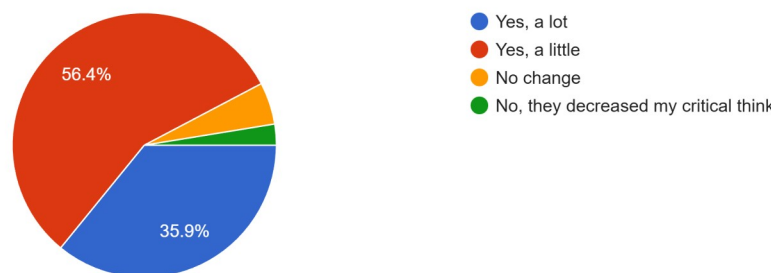


Figure 8: Perceived Changes in Students' Critical Thinking Skills

The results indicate a generally positive perception of how AI tools impact critical thinking. A majority of 56.4% of students believe that these tools have improved their skills "a little," while 35.9% feel they have improved them "a lot." Combined, over 92% of participants see a cognitive benefit to using AI. Conversely, a small minority of students reported "No change" (approximately 5.1%), and an even smaller fraction (approximately 2.6%) felt that AI tools actually decreased their critical thinking skills. This suggests that while most students find AI intellectually stimulating, a very small number perceive it as a potential hindrance to independent thought.

8. Do you think AI tools make learning faster or easier?

39 responses

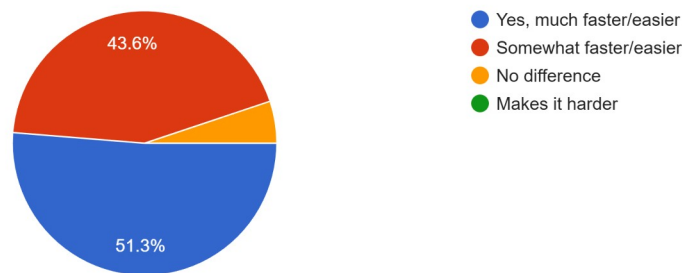


Figure 9: Correlation Between AI Usage and Exam/Assignment Performance

The survey results indicate a strong consensus that AI tools significantly improve the efficiency of the learning process. Over half of the participants, 51.3%, believe that these tools make learning "much faster/easier," while 43.6% find them to be "somewhat faster/easier". Combined, approximately 95% of students perceive a clear advantage in using AI for speed and ease of study. Only a small minority (approximately 5.1%) reported seeing "no difference," and notably, 0% of respondents felt that AI makes learning harder. This data suggests that students overwhelmingly view AI as a powerful productivity and simplification tool in their academic lives.

9. Have you become more dependent on AI tools for completing academic tasks?

39 responses

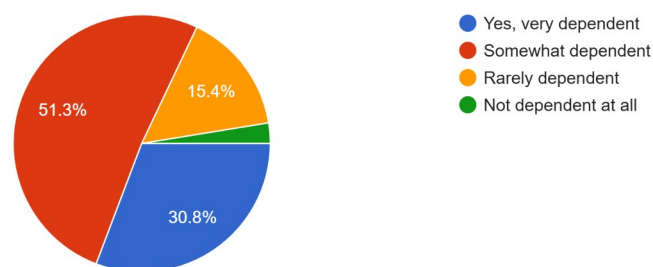


Figure 10: Level of Student Dependency on AI Tools for Academic Work

A majority of 51.3% of students describe themselves as "somewhat dependent" on these tools, while a substantial 30.8% admit to being "very dependent." Combined, over 82% of the participants acknowledge a notable level of reliance on AI to complete their tasks. In contrast, only 15.4% report being "rarely dependent," and a minimal 2.6% (represented by the green

segment) state they are "not dependent at all." This data suggests that AI has become a foundational element in the academic workflow for most students, raising important considerations about the balance between technological assistance and independent effort.

10. Does using AI tools help you perform better in exams or assignments?
39 responses

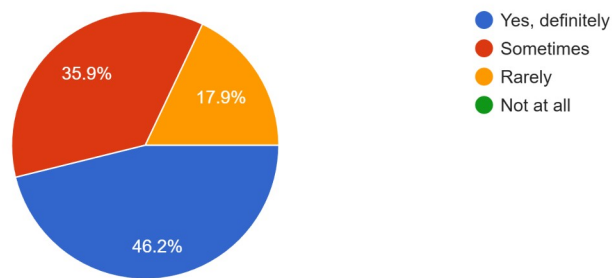


Figure 11: Changes in Student Engagement Levels During Study

The survey indicate a strong belief in the performance-enhancing capabilities of AI tools. A plurality of the respondents, 46.2%, believe that these tools "Yes, definitely" help them achieve better results in their exams or assignments. Additionally, 35.9% of participants feel that AI tools help them "Sometimes," meaning over 82% of the group associates AI use with improved academic performance. On the other hand, 17.9% of respondents feel that AI "Rarely" impacts their performance, while notably, 0% of the participants indicated that it does "Not at all" help. This data reflects a general student consensus that AI provides a competitive edge or significant support in meeting academic requirements.

Section 3 Objective: To examine ethical concerns arising from the use of AI tools in education.

11. Are you aware of your institution's policies on AI use?
39 responses

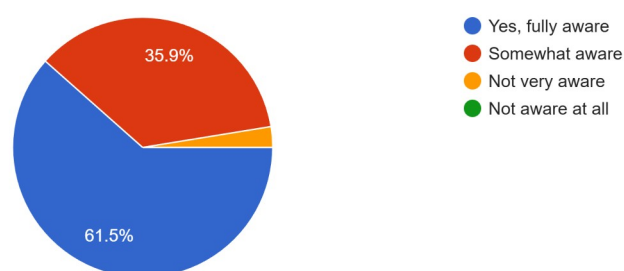


Figure 12: Student Awareness of Institutional AI Policies

The survey shows a high level of institutional awareness regarding AI regulations. A clear majority of 61.5% of students reported being "Yes, fully aware" of their institution's policies, while 35.9% indicated they are "Somewhat aware." This means that nearly 97% of the participants have at least some knowledge of the rules governing AI in their academic environment. Only a very small minority (approximately 2.6%) admitted to being "Not very aware," and notably, 0% of respondents claimed to be "Not aware at all." This suggests that the institution has been largely successful in communicating its guidelines to the student body.

12. Have you ever faced or witnessed misuse of AI tools (e.g., plagiarism)?
39 responses

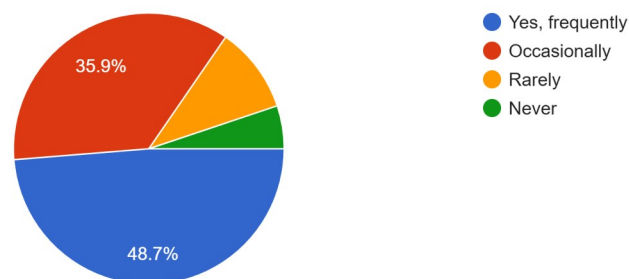


Figure 13: Frequency of Witnessed AI Misuse and Plagiarism

Nearly half of the participants, 48.7%, reported that they have witnessed or faced misuse "Yes, frequently," while an additional 35.9% have experienced it "Occasionally." Combined, approximately 84.6% of students are aware of issues like plagiarism involving AI. In contrast, only 10.3% reported that such instances occur "Rarely," and a small minority of 5.1% (represented by the green segment) stated they have "Never" witnessed any misuse. This data suggests that while AI provides educational benefits, institutional challenges regarding academic integrity and misuse are prevalent and widely recognized by the student body.

13. Do you think using AI tools for assignments can be unethical? Why or why not?

38 responses

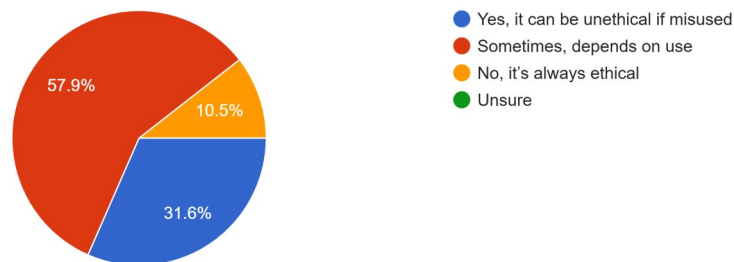


Figure 14: Student Perspectives on the Ethicality of AI Tool Usage

A significant majority of 57.9% believe that it "Sometimes, depends on use," suggesting that students view the ethicality of these tools as situational. Additionally, 31.6% of participants explicitly state "Yes, it can be unethical if misused," which highlights a strong awareness of potential academic integrity risks. Conversely, a smaller group of 10.5% feels that AI use is "No, it's always ethical," while 0% of respondents indicated they were "Unsure". Overall, nearly 90% of the surveyed students recognize that ethical boundaries exist when integrating AI into their assignments.

14. How do you ensure honesty and originality when using AI tools?

39 responses

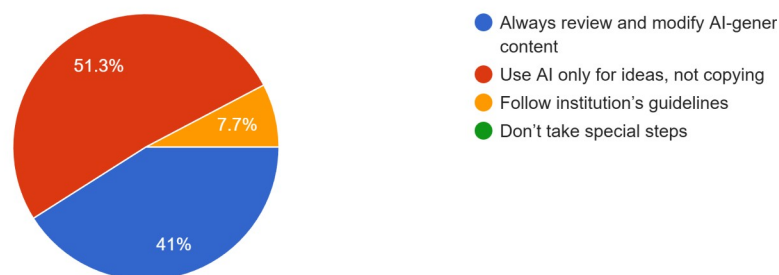


Figure 15: Strategies Adopted by Students to Ensure Originality

The survey responses indicate that most participants take active measures to maintain academic integrity when utilizing AI. Over half of the respondents, 51.3%, stated that they "Use AI only for ideas, not copying," while 41% reported that they "Always review and modify AI-generated content". A smaller segment of 7.7% ensures originality by choosing to "Follow institution's guidelines". Notably, 0% of the participants indicated that they "Don't take special

steps". This data suggests a high level of responsibility among students, with the vast majority prioritizing the use of AI as a supportive conceptual tool rather than a source for direct replication.

15. What challenges do teachers face in assessing work done with AI tools?

39 responses

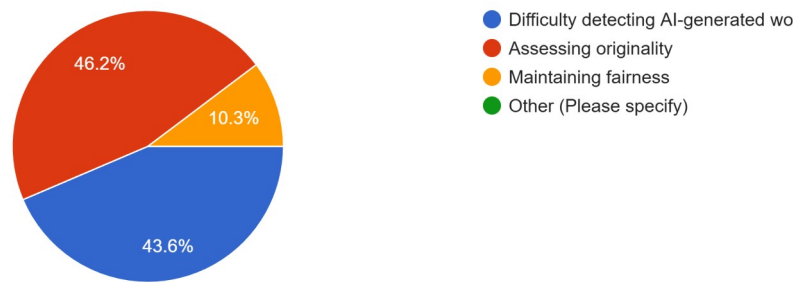


Figure 16: Teacher Challenges in Assessing AI-Assisted Work

A plurality of students, 46.2%, believe that assessing originality is the primary challenge teachers face, while 43.6% identify the difficulty in detecting AI-generated work as a major hurdle. A smaller segment, 10.3%, points to the struggle of maintaining fairness among students as a key issue. Notably, 0% of respondents selected the "Other" category. This data suggests that students are highly aware of the complexities AI introduces to traditional grading and the potential for these tools to obscure a student's true individual contribution.

Section 4 Objective: To explore strategies for promoting responsible and ethical use of AI tools in education.

16. Do you think students need training on ethical use of AI tools?

39 responses

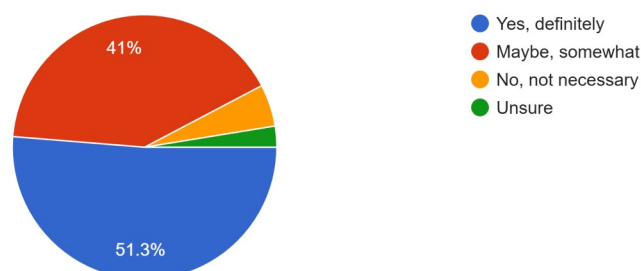


Figure 17: Student Opinions on the Necessity of Ethical AI Training

A majority of students, 51.3%, believe that such training is "Yes, definitely" required, while an additional 41% feel that it is "Maybe, somewhat" necessary. Combined, over 92% of respondents recognize at least some level of need for guidance in this area. In contrast, only a small minority of 5.1% stated that training is "No, not necessary," and a minimal 2.6% remained "Unsure". These results suggest that students are aware of the ethical complexities surrounding AI and would welcome institutional support to navigate them responsibly.

17. What do you think is the biggest risk of AI tools in education?
39 responses

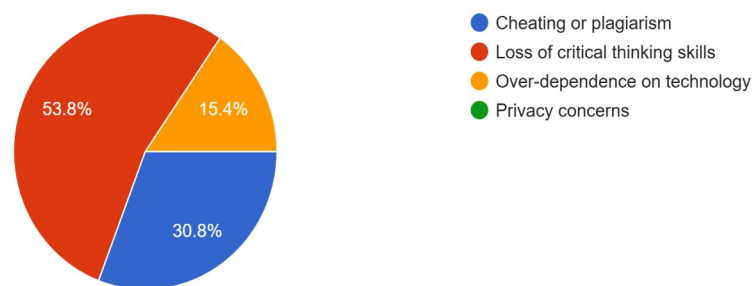


Figure 18: Primary Risks Associated with AI Tools in Education

A majority of students, 53.8%, identify the loss of critical thinking skills as the single greatest risk associated with AI in education. This is followed by cheating or plagiarism, which is seen as the primary threat by 30.8% of the participants. A smaller segment, 15.4%, believes that over-dependence on technology poses the biggest risk. Notably, 0% of respondents selected privacy concerns as their top choice. These findings suggest that while students are aware of integrity issues like plagiarism, they are most concerned about the potential for AI to diminish their own cognitive and analytical abilities.

18. How can institutions support responsible AI use among students?

39 responses

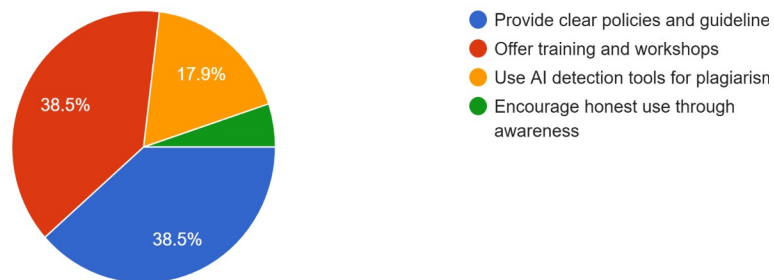


Figure 19: Preferred Institutional Strategies for Responsible AI Support

Students are equally divided on two primary methods, with 38.5% favoring the provision of clear policies and guidelines and another 38.5% advocating for training and workshops. Additionally, 17.9% of participants believe that the use of AI detection tools for plagiarism is a key supportive measure. A smaller group (approximately 5.1%) feels that institutions should encourage honest use through awareness campaigns. These findings suggest that students desire a combination of clear rules and practical education to help them navigate the complexities of AI responsibly.

19. What benefits of AI tools do you find most valuable for your learning?

39 responses

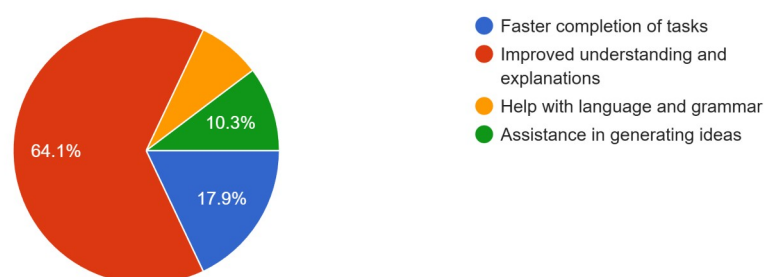


Figure 20: Most Valuable Benefits of AI Tools for Student Learning

A significant majority of 64.1% identify improved understanding and explanations as the most valuable benefit for their learning. This is followed by faster completion of tasks, which was cited by 17.9% of participants. A smaller portion of the group finds assistance in generating ideas (10.3%) and help with language and grammar (approximately 7.7%) to be the

most beneficial aspects. These findings suggest that while AI is a powerful productivity tool, its greatest perceived value lies in its ability to clarify complex concepts and enhance student comprehension.

20. Would you recommend AI tools to other students? Why or why not?
39 responses

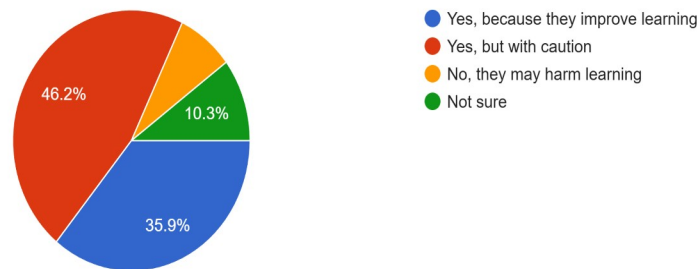


Figure 21: Student Recommendations for AI Tool Adoption Among Peers

The final survey question reveals that a vast majority of the 39 respondents hold a favorable view of AI tools, though many advocate for a balanced approach. A plurality of students, 46.2%, would recommend these tools but suggest doing so "with caution". Meanwhile, 35.9% give an unqualified recommendation because they believe AI tools "improve learning". A smaller segment of 10.3% remains "not sure" about recommending them, and only 7.7% (represented by the orange segment) would advise against it, citing concerns that they "may harm learning". Overall, over 82% of participants support the use of AI tools by their peers in some capacity.

3.3 Data Analysis

In this section, quantitative data are analyzed using descriptive statistics. The focus is on key questions related to AI integration, learning impact, and ethics.

AI Tool Integration

Question: "How frequently do you use AI tools (e.g., ChatGPT, Bard, Grammarly etc.) in your daily academic routine?"

Table 1: AI Tool Integration Analysis

Response	Count (f)	Percentage (%)
Daily (5)	22	56.41%
Weekly (4)	12	30.77%
Occasionally (3)	5	12.82%
Rarely (2)	0	0.00%
Never (1)	0	0.00%
Total	39	100%

Mean Calculation

$$\text{Mean} = \{(5 \times 22) + (4 \times 12) + (3 \times 5) + (2 \times 0) + (1 \times 0)\} / \{39\}$$

$$\text{Mean} = \{110 + 48 + 15 + 0 + 0\} / 39$$

$$\text{Mean} = 173 / 39$$

$$\approx 4.44$$

The mean is 4.44, falling between "Weekly" (4) and "Daily" (5). This indicates a very high level of regular AI integration among students.

Impact on Critical Thinking

Question: "Do you believe AI tools have improved your critical thinking and problem-solving skills?"

Table 2: Impact on Critical Thinking Analysis

Response	Count (f)	Percentage (%)
Strongly Agree (5)	14	35.90%
Agree (4)	22	56.41%
Neutral (3)	2	5.13%
Disagree (2)	1	2.56%
Strongly Disagree (1)	0	0.00%
Total	39	100%

Mean Calculation

$$\text{Mean} = \{(5 \times 14) + (4 \times 22) + (3 \times 2) + (2 \times 1) + (1 \times 0)\} / \{39\}$$

$$\text{Mean} = \{70 + 88 + 6 + 2 + 0\} / \{39\}$$

$$\text{Mean} = 166 / 39$$

$$\approx 4.26$$

The mean is 4.26, which indicates strong agreement that AI tools are perceived as beneficial for cognitive and critical thinking development.

Institutional Awareness and Ethics

Question: "Are you fully aware of your institution's policies regarding the ethical use of AI?"

Table 3: Institutional Awareness and Ethics Analysis

Response	Count (f)	Percentage (%)
Yes, fully aware (5)	24	61.54%
Somewhat aware (4)	14	35.90%
Neutral (3)	1	2.56%
Not very aware (2)	0	0.00%
Not aware at all (1)	0	0.00%
Total	39	100%

Mean Calculation

$$\text{Mean} = \{(5 \times 24) + (4 \times 14) + (3 \times 1) + (2 \times 0) + (1 \times 0)\} / \{39\}$$

$$\text{Mean} = \{120 + 56 + 3 + 0 + 0\} / \{39\}$$

$$\text{Mean} = 179 / 39$$

$$\approx 4.59$$

The mean is 4.59, falling between "Somewhat aware" (4) and "Fully aware" (5). This suggests that the institution has effectively communicated its guidelines to the majority of students.

Need for Ethical Training

Question: "Do you think there is a need for formal training on the ethical use of AI tools?"

Table 4: Need for Ethical Training Analysis

Response	Count (f)	Percentage (%)
Definitely (5)	20	51.28%
Somewhat (4)	16	41.03%
Neutral (3)	1	2.56%
Not necessary (2)	2	5.13%
Unsure (1)	0	0.00%
Total	39	100%

Mean Calculation

$$\text{Mean} = \{(5 \times 20) + (4 \times 16) + (3 \times 1) + (2 \times 2) + (1 \times 0)\} / \{39\}$$

$$\text{Mean} = \{100 + 64 + 3 + 4 + 0\} / \{39\}$$

$$\text{Mean} = 171 / 39$$

$$\approx 4.38$$

With a mean of 4.38, students strongly support the implementation of institutional strategies such as workshops and clear guidelines for responsible AI use.

Overall Grand Mean Analysis

This section synthesizes the findings from all four research dimensions: AI Tool Integration, Impact on Learning/Thinking Skills, Ethical Awareness, and Institutional Strategies. The Overall Grand Mean represents the general trend of the research findings.

Table 5: Overall Grand Mean Analysis

S.N.	Research Section	Mean Score ($\bar{x}$)	Interpretation
1	AI Tool Integration	4.44	Very High
2	Impact on Learning and Thinking Skills	4.26	Strongly Agree
3	Ethical Awareness and Integrity	4.59	Very High
4	Policy and Institutional Strategies	4.38	Strongly Agree
Total	Overall Grand Mean	4.42	Strongly Agree

Mean Calculation

$$\text{Grand Mean} = \{4.44 + 4.26 + 4.59 + 4.38\} / \{4\}$$

$$\text{Grand Mean} = 17.67 / 4$$

$$\approx 4.42$$

The calculated Overall Grand Mean of 4.42 indicates a very high level of agreement among the respondents regarding the influence and necessity of AI tools in their academic environment. Since the mean falls within the 4.21 – 5.00 range, it signifies that students overwhelmingly perceive AI as a transformative and essential tool for modern education.

The data further suggests that while students are highly integrated with AI technologies (4.44) and experience positive cognitive impacts (4.26), they are also deeply aware of the ethical risks involved (4.59). This high awareness, coupled with the strong demand for institutional guidelines (4.38), confirms that the student body is ready for a structured and ethically-governed implementation of AI in the curriculum.

3.4 Findings and Discussion

Main Findings

- i. AI tools, particularly ChatGPT, are widely used by students for academic purposes.
- ii. Students generally perceive AI tools as helpful in improving engagement and understanding.
- iii. Concerns regarding academic integrity and over-reliance on AI persist.

- iv. Awareness of institutional AI policies is limited among students.

Discussion

The findings of this study suggest that Artificial Intelligence (AI) has evolved from an optional academic aid into a core component of the learning ecosystem for Nepali students. The widespread adoption of AI tools—particularly ChatGPT—combined with frequent daily usage reflects a clear shift from traditional information-seeking practices toward more interactive, solution-oriented learning. This pattern supports Vygotsky’s concept of the *More Knowledgeable Other*, where learners benefit from immediate scaffolding to bridge gaps in understanding and advance cognitive development.

Despite the strong reliance on AI, the data reveal a notable imbalance between independent use and teacher-guided integration. While most students navigate AI tools on their own, formal instructional support remains limited. Nevertheless, students overwhelmingly report improved subject comprehension, reinforcing arguments that AI can enhance inquiry-based and self-directed learning when used effectively. At the same time, this independence exposes a significant cognitive tension. Students acknowledge short-term gains in efficiency and clarity, yet many express concern about long-term dependence and the potential erosion of critical thinking skills. This perceived risk of cognitive over-reliance illustrates the dual nature of AI as both an enabler of learning and a possible constraint on deeper analytical engagement.

Ethical considerations further complicate this landscape. Although a majority of students claim awareness of institutional guidelines, the high incidence of observed AI-related plagiarism indicates that policy knowledge does not necessarily translate into ethical practice. Students tend to view AI ethics as context-dependent, distinguishing acceptable uses such as brainstorming from unethical practices like direct content submission. These findings echo broader international concerns that rapid AI adoption has outpaced the development of clear, enforceable academic integrity frameworks.

In response, students strongly emphasize the need for institutional leadership. The demand for structured training and explicit guidelines reflects a readiness to engage with AI responsibly when proper support systems are in place. This aligns closely with UNESCO’s recommendations, which advocate for ethical AI literacy, transparent policies, and educator involvement to ensure technology enhances rather than undermines learning. Overall, the discussion underscores that sustainable AI integration requires a transition from informal, self-directed experimentation to a guided, ethically grounded, and pedagogically aligned approach.

3.5 Conclusion

The results of this study highlight the deeply embedded role of Artificial Intelligence (AI) in modern higher education, demonstrating that it functions both as a powerful learning aid and a source of ethical concern. The findings clearly show that the use of AI tools—particularly platforms such as ChatGPT—has become a routine aspect of students' academic lives rather than an optional support mechanism. Students mainly rely on these tools for problem-solving, calculations, and research-related tasks, reflecting a noticeable transition from conventional study practices toward more interactive and solution-oriented learning approaches. Although students overwhelmingly acknowledge that AI enhances their understanding of academic content and improves learning efficiency, this positive impact is accompanied by a growing concern about excessive dependence and the potential weakening of independent critical thinking skills.

From an ethical perspective, the study reveals a complex environment characterized by both awareness and vulnerability. While many students report familiarity with institutional guidelines on AI use, the frequent observation of misuse indicates that current policies and enforcement mechanisms are insufficient to address the challenges posed by rapidly advancing technologies. Students perceive the ethical use of AI as context-dependent and express a strong need for clearer institutional guidance. In conclusion, this research affirms that AI in education is neither inherently beneficial nor harmful; its impact depends largely on how it is regulated and integrated into academic practices. To ensure that AI supports learning rather than replaces cognitive effort, educational institutions must prioritize AI literacy, ethical training, and structured guidance. Such initiatives will help position AI as a tool that strengthens human intellect and academic integrity instead of undermining independent analytical skills.

3.6 Action Implications

Based on the findings of this study, several actionable strategies are proposed to ensure that AI tools contribute positively to the academic environment without compromising integrity. For **students**, the primary implication is the transition from using AI as an "answer-generator" to a "cognitive scaffold" for brainstorming and clarifying complex theories. Students should adopt a "human-in-the-loop" approach, where they critically review and modify AI-generated content to reflect their own voice, while maintaining a habit of transparently citing AI assistance to foster a culture of honesty.

For **educators**, the focus must move beyond traditional policing toward proactive pedagogical guidance. There is an urgent need to redesign assessments to be "AI-resilient" by

incorporating more in-class discussions, oral exams, or assignments requiring personal reflection—tasks that AI cannot easily replicate. Educators should also facilitate open dialogues regarding the limitations of AI to help students understand the long-term risks of analytical decline caused by over-reliance.

Finally, **institutions** must act as the primary facilitators of a balanced AI ecosystem. Rather than imposing ineffective blanket bans, institutions should develop clear and flexible AI usage policies that are updated regularly. These must be supported by comprehensive AI Literacy and Ethics training programs for both students and staff. Investing in institutional infrastructure, such as support centers and access to ethical AI tools, will ensure that technology serves as a medium for human empowerment rather than a substitute for academic rigour.

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